Chapter 1 Linear Regression

Introduction

- *ERM*
- *Gradient Descent*
- *Ridge Regression (L_2 regularization)*
- *Lasso Regression (L_1 regularization)*

1.1 Basic Knowledge

1.1.1 Linear Regression

Settings.

- Dataset: $D = \{(x_i, y_i)\}_{i=1}^n$, where $x_i \in \mathbb{R}^d$ and $y_i \in \mathbb{R}$. Here, y_i denotes the regression target, while x_i represents the input features used to predict y_i.
- Linear Model: $f(x) = w^\top x + b$, with weight $w \in \mathbb{R}^d$ and bias $b \in \mathbb{R}$.
- Linear Model: $f(x) = w^\top x + b$, with weight $w \in \mathbb{R}^d$ and bias $b \in \mathbb{R}$.

Note

This definition is equivalent to an inner product: $\hat{y} = w^\top x + b$. $\hat{y} = w^\top x + b$.

Definition 1.1 (Learnable / Trainable Parameters)

Learnable parameters are those that can be updated during the training process. ♣

Quiz. How to determine whether a parameter is learnable? How to determine w and b?

Ans: **ERM** (Empirical Risk Minimization)

- Loss function. Squared Loss (SE) is commonly used during optimization. The training objective can be written as:

$$\operatorname*{argmin}_{w,b} \frac{1}{n} \sum_{i\in[n]} \left(y_i - (w^\top x_i + b)\right)^2 \operatorname*{argmin}_{w,b} \frac{1}{n} \sum_{i\in[n]} \left(y_i - (w^\top x_i + b)\right)^2 \tag{1.1}$$

  The blue factor $1/n$ can be omitted in theoretical analysis, but is often kept in practice to stabilize the loss function during implementation.

Quiz: How to optimize the parameters?

Ans: **Gradient Descent** (as a traditional ML method). In the case of linear regression:

$$\frac{\partial \mathcal{L}}{\partial b} = -2 \sum_{i\in[n]} (y_i - w^\top x_i - b) \tag{1.2}$$

$$\frac{\partial \mathcal{L}}{\partial w} = -2 \sum_{i\in[n]} (y_i - w^\top x_i - b) x_i \tag{1.3}$$

Note

*In the field of machine learning, the gradient of a scalar with respect to a vector is itself a vector **(not a covector)**.*

This means:

$$\frac{\partial \mathcal{L}}{\partial w} = \begin{pmatrix} \frac{\partial \mathcal{L}}{\partial w_1} \\ \frac{\partial \mathcal{L}}{\partial w_2} \\ \vdots \\ \frac{\partial \mathcal{L}}{\partial w_d} \end{pmatrix} = \left(\frac{\partial \mathcal{L}}{\partial w_1}, \frac{\partial \mathcal{L}}{\partial w_2}, \cdots, \frac{\partial \mathcal{L}}{\partial w_d} \right)^\top \tag{1.4}$$

See the definition of matix derivatives (assuming no special structure in the matrix) in Matrix Cookbook Chapter 2.

Note

Here are some commonly used derivative formulas:

$$\frac{\partial x^\top x}{\partial x} = 2x \tag{1.5}$$

$$\frac{\partial a^\top x}{\partial x} = a, \quad \frac{\partial Ax}{\partial x} = A^\top \tag{1.6}$$

$$\frac{\partial x^\top Ax}{\partial x} = (A + A^\top)x \tag{1.7}$$

Remark

Both sides of an equation must have the same dimension. This principle can be used as a consistency check.

We optimize the parameters by subtracting a scalar multiple of the gradient from the parameters, considering the physical meaning of the gradient: the direction of the steepest **increase**.

Definition 1.2 (Hyperparameter)

A parameter that is fixed during optimization and specified before the training process. ♣

That is:

$$w' = w - \alpha \frac{\partial \mathcal{L}}{\partial w}, \quad b' = b - \alpha \frac{\partial \mathcal{L}}{\partial b} \tag{1.8}$$

Optimization will stop when the norm of the parameter update becomes smaller than a given hyperparameter.

1.2 Closed-Form of Linear Regression

Proposition 1.1

*Linear Regression has **Closed-Form** solution.* ♡

Settings.

- Matrix $X_0 := (x_1, \cdots, x_n)^\top$;
- Matrix $X := (X_0, \mathbb{1}) \in \mathbb{R}^{n \times (d+1)}$;
- $y = (y_1, \cdots, y_n)^\top \in \mathbb{R}^n$;
- $\hat{w} = (w^\top, b)^\top \in \mathbb{R}^{d+1}$.

Then the loss function of $\hat{w}$ can be written as:

$$\mathcal{L}(\hat{w}) = (y - X\hat{w})^\top (y - X\hat{w}) = \|y - X\hat{w}\|_2^2 \tag{1.9}$$

Here, $\|\cdot\|_p$ denotes the *p-norm* of a vector.

Note

Vectors can sometimes be treated as scalars, since linearity ensures that the validity of a proposition can be extended to any finite dimension.

Notice that the optimization stops when $\partial\mathcal{L}(\hat{w})/\partial\hat{w} = 0$. Under this condition, the parameters can be solved from the above constraint by following steps:

$$\frac{\partial\mathcal{L}(\hat{w})}{\partial\hat{w}} = -2X^\top(y - X\hat{w}) \tag{1.10}$$

Note

Both dimensional analysis and calculation using Leibniz's rule lead to the same result as the formula above:

$$\begin{aligned}\mathcal{L}(\hat{w}) &= y^\top y - 2y^\top X\hat{w} + \hat{w}^\top X^\top X\hat{w}\\ \partial_{\hat{w}}\mathcal{L}(\hat{w}) &= -2X^\top y + 2X^\top X\hat{w}\\ &= -2X^\top(y - X\hat{w})\end{aligned}$$

Remark

More matix formulas are available in Matrix Cookbook.

Thus, the target of the optimization satisfied:

$$X^\top y = X^\top X\hat{w} \tag{1.11}$$

That is:

$$\hat{w} = (X^\top X)^{-1}X^\top y \tag{1.12}$$

when $X^\top X$ invertible (non-singular / full-rank).

Example 1.1

When does $X^\top X$ not invertible?

Solution

$X \in \mathbb{R}^{n\times(d+1)}$:

- $d + 1 > n$. *Brief Proof:* $\operatorname{rank}(X^\top X) = \operatorname{rank}(X) \le \min(n, d+1) = n < d + 1$.
- *X has repeated columns. Proof is trivial.*

When $X^\top X$ isn't invertible:

1. If $\operatorname{rank}(X^\top X, X^\top y) > \operatorname{rank}(X^\top X)$, $\hat{w}$ has no solution;
2. $\hat{w}$ has infinity solution o.w.

Situation 1 is **impossible** because both $X^\top X$ and $X^\top y$ can be represented in the column space of $X^\top$. Therefore, the optimization problem must have a solution, which may be either unique or infinite.

As an infinite set of solutions makes it difficult to determine which estimate of $\hat{w}$ to choose, we apply L_2 **regularization** to linear regression, which is commonly referred to as **Ridge Regression**. That is:

$$\mathcal{L}_{L_2} := \mathcal{L}(\hat{w}) + \boxed{\lambda\|\hat{w}\|_2^2}, \tag{1.13}$$

where $\lambda > 0$ is a hyperparameter. Notice that $\|\hat{w}\|_2^2 = \sum_{i=1}^{d+1}\hat{w}_i^2$, L_2 regularization prevents any single dimension from being assigned an excessively large weight, and encourages the model to make use of more dimensions during training.

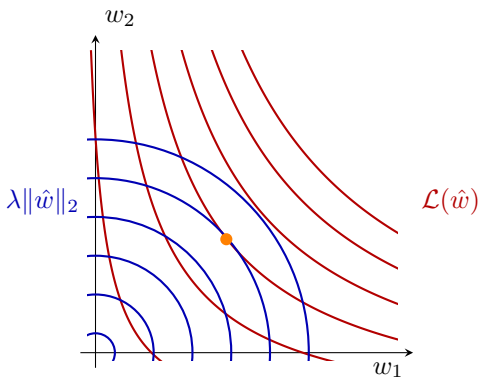

Figure 1.1: Illustration of L_2 regularization. The contours represent level sets of the regularized loss $\mathcal{L}(\hat{w}) + \lambda\|\hat{w}\|_2^2$, which take the form of concentric ellipses (circle in the plot).

During ridge regression, we minimize the $\mathcal{L}_{L_2}$:

$$\underset{\hat{w}}{\operatorname{argmin}}\,(y - X\hat{w})^\top(y - X\hat{w}) + \lambda\hat{w}^\top\hat{w} \tag{1.14}$$

The optimization stops when:

$$\frac{\partial\mathcal{L}_{L_2}}{\partial\hat{w}} = -2X^\top y + 2X^\top X\hat{w} + 2\lambda I\hat{w} = 0 \tag{1.15}$$

$$\Rightarrow (X^\top X + \lambda I)\hat{w} = X^\top y \tag{1.16}$$

Proposition 1.2

$X^\top X + \lambda I$ always invertible. ♡

Proof

Since $X^\top X$ is a real symmetric matrix, we have the eigen-decomposition $X^\top X = U\Lambda U^\top$, where $\Lambda = \operatorname{diag}(\lambda_1, \cdots, \lambda_{d+1})$. Moreover, as $X^\top X \succeq 0$ (positive semi-definite), it follows that $\forall i \in [d+1]$, $\lambda_i \geq 0$. Note that:

$$\lambda I = \lambda UU^\top \tag{1.17}$$

since U is an orthogonal matrix. Hence:

$$X^\top X + \lambda I = U(\Lambda + \lambda I)U^\top \tag{1.18}$$

For all $i \in [d+1]$, we have:

$$\lambda_i + \lambda > \lambda_i \geq 0 \tag{1.19}$$

Thus, $X^\top X + \lambda I$ is a full-rank matrix. ■

Remark

Numerical issues may still occur even if $X^\top X$ is full rank (e.g., when eigenvalues λ_k are close to zero). The L_2 regularization factor λ mitigates this issue by shifting the eigenvalues upward, thereby improving numerical stability during training.

Another regularization method often used is L_1 regularization, where the loss function is defined as:

$$\mathcal{L}_{L_1} := \mathcal{L}(\hat{w}) + \boxed{\lambda\|\hat{w}\|_1} \tag{1.20}$$

L_1 regularization can induce sparsity in $\hat{w}$, which works in contrast to L_2 regularization. Specifically, L_1 regularization encourages the model to rely on only a small subset of input features, effectively performing **feature selection**.

Linear regression with L_1 regularization is called **Lasso Regression** (Least Absolute Shrinkage and Selection Operator).

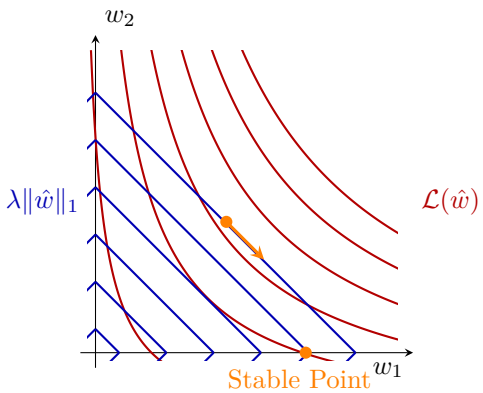

Figure 1.2: Illustration of L_1 regularization. The contours represent level sets of the regularized loss $\mathcal{L}(\hat{w}) + \lambda\|\hat{w}\|_1$, which take the form of nested diamonds (squares rotated by 45° in the plot).

1.3 Geomeric View of LR

Ideally, we would like to solve $X\hat{w} = y$. If y lies on the hypersurface

$$\mathcal{M}(X) := \mathrm{Span}(X) = \{Xw : w \in \mathbb{R}^{d+1}\} \subset \mathbb{R}^n \tag{1.21}$$

then the equation admits an exact solution. In most cases, however, $y \notin \mathcal{M}(X)$, so no exact solution exists. Nevertheless, we can always find an estimator $\hat{w}$ such that $\mathcal{P}_{\mathcal{M}(X)}y = X\hat{w}$, where $\mathcal{P}_{\mathcal{M}(X)}$ denotes the orthogonal projection onto the hypersurface $\mathcal{M}(X)$.

Proposition 1.3

$$\hat{y} = X\hat{w} \quad \Rightarrow \quad \hat{w} \textit{ is solution to LR.} \tag{1.22}$$

Proof

$$\begin{aligned} y - \hat{y} \perp \mathcal{M}(X) \quad &\Rightarrow \quad y - X\hat{w} \perp \mathcal{M}(X) \\ &\Rightarrow \quad X^\top(y - X\hat{w}) = 0 \quad \Rightarrow \quad \hat{w} = (X^\top X)^{-1}X^\top y \end{aligned}$$

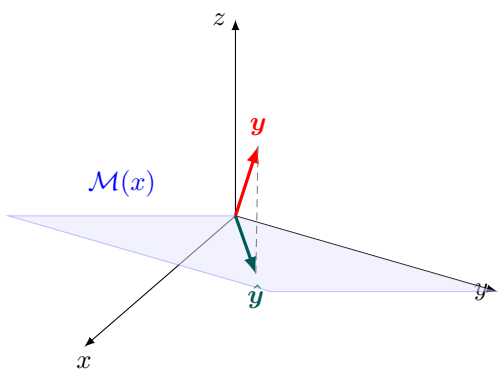

Figure 1.3: Orthogonal projection interpretation of linear regression. The predicted vector $X\hat{w}$ is obtained as the projection of y onto the hypersurface $\mathcal{M}(X) = \{Xw : w \in \mathbb{R}^{d+1}\}$, which is a linear subspace in the classical case.